

Episode 5: Once Upon a Time... (4) All First Experiences! (laughs)

The other week, my wife and I happened to be watching TV when a commercial for Bandai's plastic model "1/350 Space Battleship Yamato" came on. My wife looked at the happy-eyed middle-aged men on screen and said "I wonder if anyone actually buys this" while looking at me. There I was with the same eyes as the TV middle-aged men, grinning. "...You bought it, didn't you."

So now in our hallway sits a giant box with nowhere to put it (laughs). Man, it was huge! My wife burst out laughing when she saw that box. So, when will I actually start building it (distant stare).

Well then.

Uh, another immediate correction (sweat). The work title I mentioned last time, *Roger Rabbit*, was wrong - sorry, it was *American Rabbit*. I mistakenly wrote it in the heat of the moment. I humbly correct this. My apologies to everyone involved.

Now, the *Robotex* story.

What kind of story was it, you ask - well, they landed on a planet, and it turned out to be a planet where giant robot dinosaurs were fighting... something like that, probably... I've forgotten by now. I think it was humans and their robots cooperating to defeat bad humans and bad robots... or was it different?

Those robots had block-assembled-like forms with American comic-style black-filled shadow parts for visuals. This work was basically a promotion for selling toys - if kids watching the show wanted the robots (toys) appearing on screen, that was OK. Well, that's the same as Japanese anime. The actual toys were sent along with the "materials," but honestly they weren't very cool (bitter laugh).

So my work started with creating colour direction sheets based on the sent colour models.

Colour direction sheets - character line drawings with paint numbers written in. Which number for skin, which number for hair... drawing lines from each part of the character line drawing and writing numbers like mathematical fractions (!) The numerator is normal colour, denominator is shadow colour, something like that. For clothing colour divisions, I'd draw diagonal lines in the division parts to make it clear, or paint divisions with blue pencil so they'd copy clearly (since the copy machines available then were naturally black and white, doing this would make it appear faintly grey like screen tone).

This way, I created colour direction sheets for all necessary colour models.

(Actually, I wondered if I could show you the actual *Robotex* colour direction sheets? I searched for what I should have kept myself, but unfortunately couldn't find them. Still actively continuing the search)

Now, every work starts with meetings with the director. This was naturally my first experience (laughs). I knew theoretically what meetings were like, but when I became the actual party involved... Man, what kind of meeting was it - my memory has scattered light-years away and I can't remember (sweat). I probably was just desperately listening to the director's explanations and taking notes on the storyboard. Very different from my current self who actively speaks up a lot (laughs). I have some vague memory of the director saying "I'm hungry" and all the staff eating delivered tempura bowls before the meeting, but maybe that's wrong? (mystery)

After meetings with the director, the work of adding colour direction to cuts finally begins. As I wrote in **Episode 1** of this series, **[colour direction]** checks the content of all cuts (key animation and in-between animation) for that story and adds specifications. Originally, you add colour direction to in-between animation and order **[finishing]** (painting), but quite often I was adding colour direction to key animation.

These "collaborative works" were made beyond conventional domestic production capacity, so most of the actual work was ordered to Korean production companies. So after checking key animation deliveries domestically, in-between animation work onward through painting was done in Korea (I remember *Robotex* Episode 1 had colour direction added to key animation for about half the cuts. From Episode 2 onward, this ratio kept increasing). Because of this work flow, Japanese staff (assistant directors) were stationed in Korea to handle in-between animation checking.

Back then, assistant directors for collaborative works would fly to Korea after meetings for that work, see through to the final cut of that work, then return carrying cels as hand luggage. They'd immediately help with **saridashi** (compositing), ship the completed film to America, and finally get to rest - it was a harsh situation.

So, inputting colour direction. Nobody taught me anything (laughs). Since I had to figure it out myself, I learnt by stealing looks at the work style of **F-san**, a senior colour director about the same age as me, while breaking out in heavy sweat doing colour direction.

Like everything, this is all about experience. You do lots of it, make lots of face-burning mistakes, and learn it with your body (laughs).

Robotex was made in 30-minute TV format (actually about 20-plus minutes after commercials were cut), with about 300 cuts and roughly 8,000-10,000 animation drawings per episode. The storyboards sent from America determined the action, plus the complexity of mouth movement cels I mentioned last time, and various other reasons. Incidentally, Toei Animation TV series average about 3,000-3,500 drawings per episode with roughly 300 total cuts, so this was over twice the animation volume.

Checking and adding colour direction to this volume of cuts was naturally a first experience. And we were pressed for time.

Departing Oizumi Studio at 6 AM. We carried them by hand to Korea almost daily. Sometimes with our assistant director's hand luggage, sometimes with Korean production company staff's return flights. Everyone headed to Narita Airport carrying several large duralumin trunks.

And we absolutely had to get them on those flights. The mountain of cuts that never seemed to decrease no matter how much we worked. Every day barely finishing input by the deadline. Still, somehow we sent out all cuts, but naturally all this would come back painted.

A few days later, looking at those painted cels, I stood stunned.

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